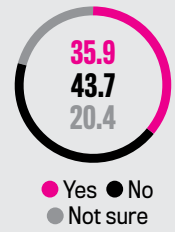
tionships. "Most people are in a rush today to get somewhere, physically and metaphorically. Stress releases such strong hormones that it can directly lower our libido. If one partner is overworked, they might not be willing to have sex, putting a strain on the relationship and the other partner," says Dr Sameer Malhotra, director of the department of mental health at Max Hospital, Saket, Delhi.

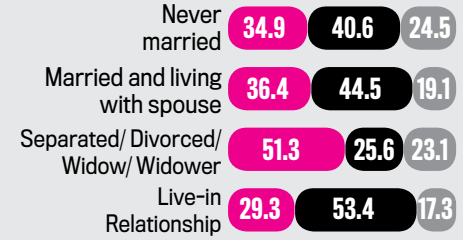
And if you thought this would push people towards self-pleasure, the findings have another surprise for you. There is a decrease in both the act, and knowledge, of masturbation. While the 2017 survey results showed that 26.5 per cent people masturbated often, that figure has fallen to 19 per cent in this survey. In fact, many Indians participated in the 'nofap' challenge, an online pledge where participants, also known as fapstronauts, try to reboot their brains by abstaining from masturbation and porn in the hope of a healthier sex life. Various websites help guide participants through it: No Fap LLC, Your Brain on Porn, Reboot Nation and Mr Mind Blowing. However, studies have shown that masturbation actually holds more positive health benefits, and abstinence might not lead to a healthier sex life. Not only does masturbation release hormones associated with happiness and pleasure such as dopamine, endorphins and oxytocin, it also helps improve sleep, self-image, even your marriage. According to a 2017 study in the *Journal of Sex Education and Therapy*, women who masturbated had greater sexual desire, higher self-esteem, required less time for sexual arousal and had more satisfactory marital and sex lives.

Ask 17-year-old Rishi Kulkarni (*name changed*), a recent high school graduate from Mumbai and a former fapstronaut himself. Life improved when he quit the challenge, he says. The reason why he took it on in the first place was because he thought masturbation would turn him into a sex addict. He displayed no other sign of addiction except that he felt the need to relieve himself once or twice a week. With no parental guidance or education on sex, an article on the benefits of the nofap challenge convinced him that he was in need of a sexual detox. "It was easy to do at first. But after four months of not masturbating, I started to feel frustrated and irritable. One day, I just happened to masturbate and immediately felt an improvement in my mood," says Kulkarni. After a visit to his school counsellor and discovering he was nowhere near sexual addiction, he abandoned the nofap challenge.

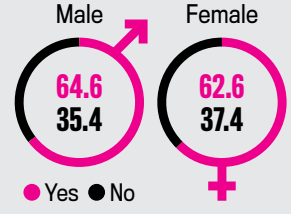
"A lot of young people are getting their education from the internet, social media forwards or pornography," says clinical sexologist Dr Prakash Kothari. "This can lead to a rather unrealistic and ignorant approach towards sex and sexual habits. The offline is very different from the online." Sexual ignorance could be having more consequences. The survey results also measure men and women's comfort and satisfaction with sex. When it comes to faking an orgasm, 45 per cent of the women respondents

IS THERE A DISPARITY IN PLEASURE BETWEEN MEN AND WOMEN?

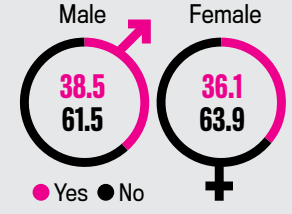




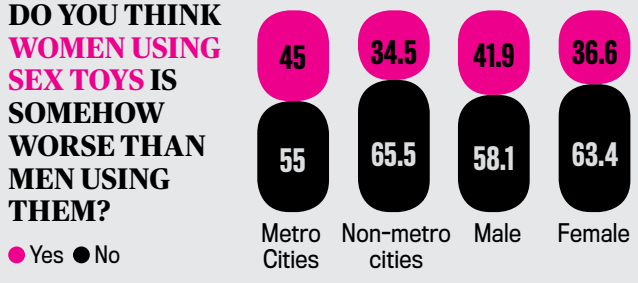
ARE YOU AWARE OF PRODUCTS THAT CAN IMPROVE FEMALE PLEASURE DURING SEX?



WOULD YOU USE SEX GADGETS TO IMPROVE YOUR OWN PLEASURE?



DO YOU THINK WOMEN USING SEX TOYS IS SOMEHOW WORSE THAN MEN USING THEM?



All figures in percentage